foreign relations and highly sensitive to any perceived encroachment upon it. Indeed, part of the reason that the Afghan delegation continually refused to disclose the details of its treaty with Soviet Russia, as demanded by the Home government, was that this was deemed an affront to their country's independence in conducting its foreign affairs. As Chelmsford tried to explain, 'It is Afghanistan's determination to parade her complete independence and she will not be driven from this attitude by anything short of war.'[85] It is with this in mind that the viceroy argued that failure of the Afghans to disclose the terms of the Soviet–Afghan treaty should not result in a breakdown of Dobbs' negotiations. As he explained further, 'if we now attempt to base our policy on what is not any longer practical politics we shall not secure a Treaty. We shall be playing into the hands of the Bolsheviks, leaving them a free field and a very fruitful field for machinations directed against us.'[86]

Nevertheless, the India Office disagreed and, in March 1921, the matter was brought to the Cabinet. During the discussion 'stress was laid on the extent of the concessions we had offered the Amir, including the raising of the subsidy... and, above all, the surrender of our control over Afghan foreign policy, all of which justified us in insisting on a substantial quid pro quo'.[87] *(The fact that the Home government saw the end of its control over Afghan foreign affairs as a 'concession' is telling: as if it had given up this privilege out of magnanimity and not necessity.) The decision was taken to instruct Dobbs not to sign any agreement with Afghanistan until the Cabinet had had a chance to consider the terms of the Soviet–Afghan Treaty.*[88] *For Chelmsford, this was highly irritating. What the viceroy had tried to point out was that the only way Britain could obtain the concessions it was insisting on was through force of arms and, since it was 'on India and Indian resources, financial and militarily, that the brunt would fall' of any such campaign against Afghanistan, the Indian government thus had the right to be listened to.*[89] *As Chelmsford complained to Montagu, the Indian government should be given more freedom in its dealings with Afghanistan, while those in London should trust those in Delhi to make the right decisions.*[90]

Such concerns were soon no longer Chelmsford's, however, as in April 1921 Lord Reading replaced him as viceroy. The relationship between